Westbrook City Council

~ Special Meeting ~

Date: Monday, June 15, 2026
Time: 7:00 PM
Location: Westbrook High School (Room 114), 125 Stroudwater St. (Hybrid via Zoom)
Video: https://vimeo.com/1201588929
Packet: https://www.westbrookmaine.gov/AgendaCenter/ViewFile/Agenda/_06152026-1012

Timestamps below are clickable [0:00]-style links — they jump straight to that moment in the video.

This summary highlights the meeting's key discussions and decisions, with direct quotes and timestamps for verification — it is not a substitute for watching the full meeting. *Summarization necessarily condenses and selects; for complete context, nuance, and anything not covered here, watch the full video at the link above. (Produced by: WestbrookCurrents.com)*

Mayor's Message: Staff Transitions & Infrastructure Updates

Jerry Bryant's Retirement, New Hires & Project Updates [1:23]

Discussion Summary

Jerry Bryant's retirement became official Friday, June 5 (City Hall closed early for a staff send-off); the planned succession is now complete, with Angela Holmes as City Administrator and Monique Cornett now the permanent Director of Economic & Community Development. The City has hired a new Tax Collector, Melissa Littlehale (starting June 22), while Laura King continues as Interim Finance Director ahead of a search for a permanent Finance Director (Councilor Chau will join the interview team).

Sewer smoke testing in Ward 1 (part of the City's combined-sewer-overflow reduction plan, conducted by consultant Wright-Pierce) identified roughly 46 instances of smoke escaping from private-property connections; affected property owners will receive letters outlining required fixes.

A new Route 302 Corridor Study, a partnership with GPCOG, Portland, Windham, Raymond, and MaineDOT, will study a 22-mile stretch of Route 302 for prioritized improvement projects, with public visioning sessions this summer into fall and draft recommendations expected to Council by February/March 2027.

PFAS soil testing at the Warren Baseball Field, the Fraser Softball Field, and the shared Vocational Center/Canal School field (EPA-approved, USEPA Brownfield Award funded via GPCOG, supervised by Credere Associates) takes place later this month, with results expected in August and a presentation by Project Manager Robyn Saunders planned for a September Council meeting.

The City was awarded $195,000 in Community Development Block Grant funding for the Riverwalk South Lighting Project (Ash Street to the Black Bridge, ~$626,000 total project cost), with a formal acceptance/expenditure request expected by late summer. An additional Council meeting was announced for July 20 to handle a heavy summer workload.

A policy review of private ways is underway: the City has historically provided plowing and/or trash collection on roughly two dozen private streets, found inconsistent with state statute; staff will bring recommendations to the Facilities & Streets Committee before winter, likely requiring public easements or a shift to resident-procured services.

Other items: a Juneteenth proclamation (observance Friday, June 19, Riverbank Park); the City will march in the Portland Pride Parade (June 20); confirmation the City does not use automated license-plate-recognition ("flock") cameras; and an introduction of Michael Thomas, newly installed Commander of the Stephen W. Manchester American Legion Post 62.

Key Decisions

✓ Informational — no vote taken.

Action Items

None.

Mayor's Message: Addressing Noise Complaints

Police Chief Sean Lally on Noise Enforcement Tools [14:27]

Discussion Summary

Chief Lally described the City's existing enforcement tools: hours restrictions on construction noise, motor vehicle noise law, the Peace and Good Order ordinance (Ch. 234), the City's disorderly-housing ordinance (which he said only Westbrook and Portland have in Maine), and the state disorderly conduct statute — applied using a "reasonableness" standard rather than a fixed decibel limit (vehicle noise is the one category already decibel-regulated, in the mid-80s).

Councilor Turcotte relayed a constituent's question about adopting decibel-based limits. Chief Lally said the department could train officers and acquire decibel meters if the Council adopted such an ordinance, but said he'd rather rely on officers responding to specific complaints and having a conversation with the offending party, and encouraged residents to keep calling when an issue is actively occurring.

Key Decisions

✓ Informational — no vote taken.

Action Items

None.

Mayor's Message: Growth & Development Review and Trends

Director Rebecca Spitella's Residential Growth Data Presentation [20:54]

Discussion Summary

Prompted by a cluster of residential development applications reaching the Planning Board at once (mostly workshop-stage, not final approvals), Director Spitella presented data addressing recurring public concerns. Building permits averaged 120 units/year (2016–2020) and 134 units/year (2021–2026), up from 73/year (2006–2010) and 67/year (2011–2015) — confirming faster growth than 20 years ago, though Westbrook still trails neighboring Windham and Scarborough in most years.

Housing mix (2018–2024): 34% single-family, 14% duplex, 53% multifamily (3+ units); multifamily units, typically one-to-two bedrooms, are less likely to house school-age children. School enrollment remains steady or declining despite housing growth, below the 2005 baseline of 2,565 students; the 2016 School Impact Study significantly over-projected enrollment under both of its models — a reminder, she said, that such studies are planning tools, not guarantees.

On traffic, she explained site plan review requires that a project not exceed a roadway's physical capacity and may require off-site safety improvements, but general congestion and speeding are regional issues outside any single development's control. She showed several completed multifamily developments integrated into single-family neighborhoods and announced tentative public post-construction site walks for the weekend of August 8–9.

Key Decisions

✓ Informational — no vote taken.

Action Items

None.

New Business — Orders (First Reading, Two Readings Required)

Order 2026-67 — Bulletproof Vest Partnership Grant [48:06]

Found on page 9 of the packet.

Discussion Summary

Accepts an $8,455.08 U.S. Department of Justice Bulletproof Vest Partnership grant (50% reimbursement of police vest costs).

Key Decisions

✓ Passed on first reading (voice vote).

Action Items

None.

Order 2026-68 — Beaver Pond Beautification Project [49:22]

Found on page 14 of the packet.

Discussion Summary

Authorizes up to $11,000 in open space funds ($8,000 to Portland Trails for trail access/signage, $3,000 for water quality monitoring equipment). Councilor Chau relayed detailed constituent questions from a neighborhood walk covering the project's passive-recreation scope, wildlife/debris impact, parking, and public safety; Director Spitella's answers (an existing 15-foot sidewalk/waterline buffer is sufficient; no plan to reinstall removed fencing; the City treats the pond like any other unsupervised water body) satisfied the councilor's questions.

Key Decisions

✓ Passed on first reading (voice vote).

Action Items

None.

Order 2026-69 — Public Safety Health & Wellness Screening Funds [1:02:15]

Found on page 23 of the packet.

Discussion Summary

Amends two prior orders to redistribute $104,993.91 in unspent regional grant funds, authorizing Westbrook's $9,695.62 share ($7,210 to Guiding Light Behavioral Health, $2,485.63 to Sigma Tactical Wellness) for additional staff health and wellness screenings.

Key Decisions

✓ Passed on first reading (voice vote).

Action Items

None.

Order 2026-70 — Replacement Zero-Turn Mowers [1:04:20]

Found on page 26 of the packet.

Discussion Summary

Authorizes $27,229.51 for two replacement zero-turn mowers from Hall Implement Co. of Windham, ME.

Key Decisions

✓ Passed on first reading (voice vote).

Action Items

None.

Order 2026-71 — Replacement One-Ton Trucks [1:05:27]

Found on page 32 of the packet.

Discussion Summary

Authorizes $287,323 for the purchase and upfit of three replacement one-ton trucks for Engineering & Public Services.

Key Decisions

✓ Passed on first reading (voice vote).

Action Items

None.

Order 2026-72 — Replacement Single-Axle Plow Truck [1:06:48]

Found on page 82 of the packet.

Discussion Summary

Authorizes $284,932 for a replacement single-axle plow truck from Freightliner and Western Star of Maine.

Key Decisions

✓ Passed on first reading (voice vote).

Action Items

None.

Order 2026-73 — FY2027 Animal Shelter Contract [1:07:58]

Found on page 106 of the packet.

Discussion Summary

Approves the FY2027 animal shelter services contract with the Animal Refuge League of Greater Portland, $27,948 for the year (Westbrook's discounted host-community rate of $1.37/capita, versus $1.43 for other member communities).

Key Decisions

✓ Passed on first reading (voice vote).

Action Items

None.

Order 2026-74: Tennis Court Repairs (5–1)

Order 2026-74 — Westbrook High School Tennis Court Repairs [1:09:33]

Found on page 114 of the packet.

Discussion Summary

Authorizes a $9,000 City contribution toward Westbrook High School tennis court repairs. Councilor Turcotte asked why the City was subsidizing a school facility; City Administrator Holmes explained the backstory: the School Department requested a 50/50 cost-share (against an initial $30,000 estimate) for emergency crack repairs. Director of Public Services Eric Dudley proposed accelerating the City's planned FY2027 takeover of high school parking-lot sweeping services into spring 2026, applying the resulting ~$6,000 in school savings toward the City's share; the final repair bill came to $22,525.20, landing the City's contribution at $9,000.

Councilor Chau supported the item (citing public use of the courts) but voiced frustration that the cost-sharing arrangement ran one direction, suggesting the School Department pursue broader regional collaboration (Gorham, Scarborough, South Portland, Portland) on similar shared facility costs going forward.

Key Decisions

✓ Passed 5–1 by show of hands; the transcript does not name the dissenting councilor.

Action Items

None.

Order 2026-75: FY2027 Annual Vendor Lists

Order 2026-75 — General Fund & Sewer Fund Annual Vendor Lists [1:19:04]

Found on page 119 of the packet.

Discussion Summary

Approves the FY2027 annual vendor lists. Councilor Chau asked for future vendor-list additions to include brief justifications given the number of new entries this year; staff agreed to build that into the annual process. Councilor Turcotte raised a vendor/invoice-fraud concern given that annual vendor lists are public record, asking what internal controls confirm payments go to the correct party (not just that a bill is accurate); staff committed to walk through the City's procurement/payment-verification process at a future meeting.

Key Decisions

✓ Passed on first reading (voice vote).

Action Items

None.

Orders 2026-76 & 2026-77: Millbrook Estates TIF Amendment & Millbrook Estates III

[1:26:53] These two connected items — both requiring a public hearing at the July 6, 2026 meeting before final adoption — drew the evening's most substantive debate. Tyler Norod, President of Westbrook Development

Corporation, presented a single proposal covering both: carving a 0.91-acre parcel out of the existing 22-acre Millbrook Estates TIF district (Order 2026-76) and designating that parcel as a new "Millbrook Estates III" affordable-housing TIF district with its own Credit Enhancement Agreement (Order 2026-77), to fund a 36-unit, three-story senior housing building (at least 80% of units restricted to residents at or below 60% of area median income). Norod cited Westbrook's median home sale price (~$458,000) against a median household income of ~$85,000, average one-bedroom rents of $2,200–$2,400/month, and roughly 40% of Westbrook households falling within the project's income-eligibility range.

Point/Counterpoint — public opposition. Two residents spoke against the proposal:

> *"[People at the time] knew that times would change... They also knew that short-term fixes often result in long-term remorse... Why would we destroy the green space that is supposed to be protected... I ask you honor their commitments and foresight and vote no."*

— Beth Paulson Omstead (245 Methodist Rd., abutting property owner) [1:40:36]

Omstead argued a 1990s-era understanding had capped development at the complex's existing four residential "wings," and that this TIF amendment functions as a workaround of that understanding; she also raised concern about Westbrook Development Corporation's scale as the City's largest developer/landlord and noted past rejections of its expansion proposals in Cumberland and Arundel. Director Spitella, researching the question live, said she found no such restriction written into the original 1990/1992 subdivision plans, and that a 2024 contract-zone amendment (reviewed by the Planning Board and approved by Council) is what specifically increased the parcel's allowed density and unit count for this proposal.

> *"[With a TIF], we're actually paying the project companies 75% of the tax revenue coming in for the next thirty years, and the City of Westbrook is only getting twenty-five percent... non-TIF construction is clearly better for the city and the taxpayers."*

— Mark Fournier (75 Walker St., via Zoom) [1:41:09]

Fournier asked whether a published taxpayer-impact analysis exists for this TIF and noted roughly 20 active TIF districts citywide. Mayor Morse and Director Cornett responded that the parcel is already within an existing TIF district regardless of this vote (the amendment only resets the increment-capture clock for the new building), that affordable-housing TIFs funded through Maine's low-income tax credit program are currently the only mechanism for building new subsidized housing nationally, and pointed to packet detail (around page 163) on the TIF's purpose and projected impacts. Councilor Chau gave an extended, informal defense of the City's broader TIF strategy, framing TIF districts as sheltering assessed property value from the state's school-funding formula and noting that a separate municipal TIF (Arcadia) funds Westbrook Improvement Corporation projects such as the boardwalk, Saccarappa Park, and Westbrook Commons. Councilor Rairdon spoke in strong support, citing a long personal record backing Westbrook Housing Authority's affordable senior-housing developments, while noting he had opposed a separate, non-affordable private TIF project in the past over inadequate affordable-housing commitments.

Key Decisions

✓ Order 2026-76 (TIF district amendment) passed unanimously [2:06:39] on first reading, read by title only; public hearing and final vote scheduled July 6, 2026.

✓ Order 2026-77 (Millbrook Estates III district & Credit Enhancement Agreement) passed unanimously [2:07:49] on first reading, read by title only; public hearing and final vote scheduled July 6, 2026.

Closing

Second Public Comment, Referrals, Committee Reports & Adjournment [2:07:52]

Discussion Summary

No second public comment, no referrals, no committee report updates, and no executive session. Meeting adjourned by unanimous vote.

Key Decisions

✓ **Motion to adjourn passed, unanimous.**

Action Items

None.

How this was made

This summary was produced from the meeting video (linked above, hosted on the City's Vimeo showcase). The audio was downloaded with Downie 4 and transcribed with speaker diarization using MacWhisper. Claude (Anthropic's AI) cross-checked names and figures against the official packet and the city council roster, attributed speakers from context (introductions, roll-call order, direct address by the presiding officer) rather than the raw diarization labels alone, and drafted this summary and the quoted excerpts. Quotes are lightly cleaned of filler words/false starts but not reworded. Review tier: Not reviewed.

Produced by Westbrook Currents — westbrookcurrents.com